

'Abdon! Abdon!' vociferated Planchet, from the window.

'Bring the horse!' shouted D'Artagnan.

'Bring the horse!' screamed Planchet.

'Now give ten livres to the postilion,' said D'Artagnan, in the tone he would have employed in commanding a maneuver; 'two lads to bring up the first two bags, two to bring up the two last,—and move, Mordieux! be lively!'

Planchet rushed down the stairs, as if the devil had been at his heels. A moment later the lads ascended the stairs, bending beneath their burden. D'Artagnan sent them off to their garrets, carefully closed the door, and addressing Planchet, who, in his turn, looked a little wild,—

'Now, we are by ourselves,' said he; and he spread upon the floor a large cover, and emptied the first bag into it. Planchet did the same with the second; then D'Artagnan, all in a tremble, let out the precious bowels of the third with a knife. When Planchet heard the provoking sound of the silver and gold—when he saw bubbling out of the bags the shining crowns, which glittered like fish from the sweep-net—when he felt himself plunging his hands up to the elbows in that still rising tide of yellow and white coins, a giddiness seized him, and like a man struck by lightning, he sank heavily down upon the enormous heap, which his weight caused to roll away in all directions. Planchet, suffocated with joy, had lost his senses. D'Artagnan threw a glass of white wine in his face, which incontinently recalled him to life.

'Ah! good heavens! good heavens! good heavens!' said Planchet, wiping his moustache and beard.

At that time, as they do now, grocers wore the cavalier moustache and the lansquenet beard, only the money baths, already rare in those days, have become almost unknown now.

'Mordieux!' said D'Artagnan, 'there are a hundred thousand livres for you, partner. Draw your share, if you please, and I will draw mine.'

'Oh! the lovely sum! Monsieur d'Artagnan, the lovely sum!'

'I confess that half an hour ago I regretted that I had to give you so much; but now I no longer regret it; thou art a brave grocer, Planchet. There, let us close our accounts, for, as they say, short reckonings make long friends.'

'Oh! rather, in the first place, tell me the whole history,' said Planchet; 'that must be better than the money.'

'Ma foi!' said D'Artagnan, stroking his moustache, 'I can't say no; and if ever the historian turns to me for information, he will be able to say he has not dipped his bucket into a dry spring. Listen, then, Planchet, I will tell you all about it.'

'And I shall build piles of crowns,' said Planchet. 'Begin, my dear master.'

'Well, this is it,' said D'Artagnan, drawing his breath.

'And that is it,' said Planchet, picking up his first handful of crowns.

Chapter 38: The French Grocer in the Seventeenth Century

‘Twenty thousand livres!’ murmured he. ‘Twenty thousand livres, and yet—’

D’Artagnan, with his neck elongated, his legs stretched out, and his hands hanging listlessly, looked like a statue of discouragement. Planchet drew up a sigh from the deepest cavities of his breast.

‘Well,’ said he, ‘I see how it is. Let us be men! It is all over, is it not? The principal thing is, monsieur, that your life is safe.’

‘Doubtless! doubtless!—life is something—but I am ruined!’

‘Cordieu! monsieur!’ said Planchet, ‘If it is so, we must not despair for that; you shall become a grocer with me; I shall take you for my partner, we will share the profits, and if there should be no more profits, well, why then we shall share the almonds, raisins and prunes, and we will nibble together the last quarter of Dutch cheese.’

D’Artagnan could hold out no longer. ‘Mordieux!’ cried he, with great emotion, ‘thou art a brave fellow, on my honour, Planchet. You have not been playing a part, have you? You have not seen the pack-horse with the bags under the shed yonder?’

‘What horse? What bags?’ said Planchet, whose trembling heart began to suggest that D’Artagnan was mad.

‘Why, the English bags, Mordieux!’ said D’Artagnan, all radiant, quite transfigured.

‘Ah! good God!’ articulated Planchet, drawing back before the dazzling fire of his looks.

‘Imbecile!’ cried D’Artagnan, ‘you think me mad! Mordieux! On the contrary, never was my head more clear, or my heart more joyous. To the bags, Planchet, to the bags!’

‘But to what bags, good heavens!’

D’Artagnan pushed Planchet towards the window.

‘Under that shed yonder, don’t you see a horse?’

‘Yes.’

‘Don’t you see how his back is laden?’

‘Yes, yes!’

‘Don’t you see your lad talking with the postilion?’

‘Yes, yes, yes!’

‘Well, you know the name of that lad, because he is your own. Call him.’

D'Artagnan entered with a bent back and a dull eye: the Gascon had an idea with regard to Planchet.

'Good God!' thought the grocer, looking earnestly at the traveller, 'he looks sad!' The musketeer sat down.

'My dear Monsieur d'Artagnan!' said Planchet, with a horrible palpitation of the heart. 'Here you are! and your health?'

'Tolerably good, Planchet, tolerably good!' said D'Artagnan, with a profound sigh.

'You have not been wounded, I hope?'

'Phew!'

'Ah, I see,' continued Planchet, more and more alarmed, 'the expedition has been a trying one?'

'Yes,' said D'Artagnan. A shudder ran down Planchet's back. 'I should like to have something to drink,' said the musketeer, raising his head piteously.

Planchet ran to the cupboard, and poured out to D'Artagnan some wine in a large glass. D'Artagnan examined the bottle.

'What wine is that?' asked he.

'Alas! that which you prefer, monsieur,' said Planchet; 'that good old Anjou wine, which was one day nearly costing us all so dear.'

'Ah!' replied D'Artagnan, with a melancholy smile, 'Ah! my poor Planchet, ought I still to drink good wine?'

'Comel my dear master,' said Planchet, making a super-human effort, whilst all his contracted muscles, his pallor and his trembling betrayed the most acute anguish. 'Comel I have been a soldier and consequently have some courage; do not make me linger, dear Monsieur d'Artagnan; our money is lost, is it not?'

Before he answered, D'Artagnan took his time, and that appeared an age to the poor grocer. Nevertheless he did nothing but turn about on his chair.

'And if that were the case,' said he, slowly, moving his head up and down, 'if that were the case, what would you say, my dear friend?'

Planchet, from being pale, turned yellow. It might have been thought he was going to swallow his tongue, so full became his throat, so red were his eyes!

Chapter XXXIX

Mazarin's Gaming Party



IN a large chamber of the Palais Royal, hung with a dark coloured velvet, which threw into strong relief the gilded frames of a great number of magnificent pictures, on the evening of the arrival of the two Frenchmen, the whole court was assembled before the alcove of M. le Cardinal de Mazarin, who gave a card party to the king and queen.

A small screen separated three prepared tables. At one of these tables the king and the two queens were seated. Louis XIV, placed opposite to the young queen, his wife, smiled upon her with an expression of real happiness. Anne of Austria held the cards against the cardinal, and her daughter-in-law assisted her in the game, when she was not engaged in smiling at her husband. As for the cardinal, who was lying on his bed with a weary and careworn face, his cards were held by the Comtesse de Soissons, and he watched them with an incessant look of interest and cupidity.

The cardinal's face had been painted by Bernouin; but the rouge, which glowed only on his cheeks, threw into stronger contrast the sickly pallor of his countenance and the shining yellow of his brow. His eyes alone acquired a more brilliant luster from this auxiliary, and upon those sick man's eyes were, from time to time, turned the uneasy looks of the king, the queen, and the courtiers. The fact is, that the two eyes of the Signor Mazarin were the stars more or less brilliant in which the France of the seventeenth century read its destiny every evening and every morning.

Monseigneur neither won nor lost; he was, therefore, neither gay nor sad. It was a stagnation in which, full of pity for him, Anne of Austria would not have willingly left him; but in order to attract the attention

of the sick man by some brilliant stroke, she must have either won or lost. To win would have been dangerous, because Mazzarin would have changed his indifference into an ugly grimace; to lose would likewise have been dangerous, because she must have cheated, and the infanter, who watched her game, would, doubtless, have exclaimed against her partiality for Mazzarin. Profiting by this calm, the courtiers were chatting. When not in a bad humour, M. de Mazzarin was a very debonnaire prince, and he, who prevented nobody from singing, provided they paid, was not tyrant enough to prevent people from talking, provided they made up their minds to lose.

They were therefore chatting. At the first table, the king's younger brother, Philip, Duc d'Anjou, was admiring his handsome face in the glass of a box. His favourite, the Chevalier de Lorraine, leaning over the back of the prince's chair, was listening, with secret envy, to the Comte de Guiche, another of Philip's favourites, who was relating in choice terms the various vicissitudes of fortune of the royal adventurer Charles II. He told, as so many fabulous events, all the history of his peripatinations in Scotland, and his terrors when the enemy's party was so closely on his track; of nights spent in trees, and days spent in hunger and combats. By degrees, the fate of the unfortunate king interested his auditors so greatly, that the play languished even at the royal table, and the young king, with a pensive look and downcast eye, followed, without appearing to give any attention to it, the smallest details of this Odyssey, very picturesquely related by the Comte de Guiche.

The Comtesse de Soissons interrupted the narrator: 'Confess, count, you are inventing.'

'Madame, I am repeating like a parrot all the stories related to me by different Englishmen. To my shame I am compelled to say, I am as exact as a copy.'

'Charles II would have died before he could have endured all that.'

Louis XIV raised his intelligent and proud head. 'Madame,' said he, in a grave tone, still partaking something of the timid child, 'monsieur le cardinal will tell you that during my minority the affairs of France were in jeopardy,—and that if I had been older, and obliged to take sword in hand, it would sometimes have been for the purpose of procuring the evening meal.'

'No, pardieu! I was one already, having nothing. Let us change.'

'Then be prodigal.'

'Still less, Mordieux! Debts terrify me. Creditors appear to me, by anticipation, like those devils who turn the damned upon the gridirons, and as patience is not my dominant virtue, I am always tempted to thrash those devils.'

'You are the wisest man I know, and stand in no need of advice from any one. Great fools must they be who think they have anything to teach you. But are we not at the Rue Saint Honore?'

'Yes, dear Athos.'

'Look yonder, on the left, that small, long white house is the hotel where I lodge. You may observe that it has but two stories; I occupy the first; the other is let to an officer whose duties oblige him to be absent eight or nine months in the year,—so I am in that house as in my own home, without the expense.'

'Oh! how well you manage, Athos! What order and what liberality! They are what I wish to unite! But, of what use trying! that comes from birth, and cannot be acquired.'

'You are a flatterer! Well! adieu, dear friend. A propos, remember me to Master Planchet; he always was a bright fellow.'

'And a man of heart, too, Athos. Adieu.'

And the separated. During all this conversation, D'Arragnan had not for a moment lost sight of a certain pack-horse, in whose panniers, under some hay, were spread the sacoches (messenger's bags) with the port-manteau. Nine o'clock was striking at Saint-Merri. Planchet's helps were shutting up his shop. D'Arragnan stopped the postilion who rode the pack-horse, at the corner of the Rue des Lombards, under a pent-house, and calling one of Planchet's boys, he desired him not only to take care of the two horses, but to watch the postilion; after which he entered the shop of the grocer, who had just finished supper, and who, in his little private room, was, with a degree of anxiety, consulting the calendar, on which, every evening, he scratched out the day that was past. At the moment when Planchet, according to his daily custom, with the back of his pen, erased another day, D'Arragnan kicked the door with his foot, and the blow made his steel spur jingle. 'Oh! good Lord!' cried Planchet. The worthy grocer could say no more; he had just perceived his partner.

'No: after having embraced Raoul, with whom I have appointed a meeting at my hotel, I shall set out immediately for La Fère.'

'Well, adieu, then, dear and true friend.'

'Au revoir! I should rather say, for why can you not come and live with me at Blois? You are free, you are rich, I shall purchase for you, if you like, a handsome estate in the vicinity of Cheverny or of Bracieux. On the one side you will have the finest woods in the world, which join those of Chambord; on the other, admirable marshes. You who love sporting, and who, whether you admit it or not, are a poet, my dear friend, you will find pheasants, rail and teal, without counting sunsets and excursions on the water, to make you fancy yourself Nimrod and Apollo themselves. While awaiting the purchase, you can live at La Fère, and we shall go together to fly our hawks among the vines, as Louis XIII used to do. That is a quiet amusement for old fellows like us.'

D'Artagnan took the hands of Athos in his own. 'Dear count,' said he, 'I shall say neither "Yes" nor "No." Let me pass in Paris the time necessary for the regulation of my affairs, and accustom myself, by degrees, to the heavy and glittering idea which is beating in my brain and dazzles me. I am rich, you see, and from this moment until the time when I shall have acquired the habit of being rich, I know myself, and I shall be an insupportable animal. Now, I am not enough of a fool to wish to appear to have lost my wits before a friend like you, Athos. The cloak is handsome, the cloak is richly gilded, but it is new, and does not seem to fit me.'

Athos smiled. 'So be it,' said he. 'But a propos of this cloak, dear D'Artagnan, will you allow me to offer you a little advice?'

'Yes, willingly.'

'You will not be angry?'

'Proceed.'

'When wealth comes to a man late in life or all at once, that man, in order not to change, must most likely become a miser—that is to say, not spend much more money than he had done before; or else become a prodigal, and contract so many debts as to become poor again.'

'Oh! but what you say looks very much like a sophism, my dear philosophic friend.'

'I do not think so. Will you become a miser?'

'Thanks to God,' said the cardinal, who spoke for the first time, 'your majesty exaggerates, and your supper has always been ready with that of your servants.'

The king coloured.

'Oh!' cried Philip, inconsiderately, from his place, and without ceasing to admire himself, — 'I recollect once, at Melun, the supper was laid for nobody, and that the king ate two-thirds of a slice of bread, and abandoned to me the other third.'

The whole assembly, seeing Mazarin smile, began to laugh. Courtiers flatter kings with the remembrance of past distresses, as with the hopes of future good fortune.

'It is not to be denied that the crown of France has always remained firm upon the heads of its kings,' Anne of Austria hastened to say, 'and that it has fallen off of that of the king of England; and when by chance that crown oscillated a little,—for there are throne-quakes as well as earthquakes,—every time, I say, that rebellion threatened it, a good victory restored tranquillity.'

'With a few gems added to the crown,' said Mazarin.

The Comte de Guiche was silent: the king composed his countenance, and Mazarin exchanged looks with Anne of Austria, as if to thank her for her intervention.

'It is of no consequence,' said Philip, smoothing his hair, 'my cousin Charles is not handsome, but he is very brave, and fought like a land-sknecht; and if he continues to fight thus, no doubt he will finish by gaining a battle, like Rocroi—'

'He has no soldiers,' interrupted the Chevalier de Lorraine.

'The king of Holland, his ally, will give him some. I would willingly have given him some if I had been king of France.'

Louis XIV blushed excessively. Mazarin affected to be more attentive to his game than ever.

'By this time,' resumed the Comte de Guiche, 'the fortune of this unhappy prince is decided. If he has been deceived by Monk, he is ruined. Imprisonment, perhaps death, will finish what exiles, battles, and privations have commenced.'

Mazarin's brow became clouded.

'It is certain,' said Louis XIV, 'that his majesty Charles II, has quitted the Hague?'

'Quite certain, your majesty,' replied the young man; 'my father has received a letter containing all the details; it is even known that the king has landed at Dover; some fishermen saw him entering the port; the rest is still a mystery.'

'I should like to know the rest,' said Philip, impetuously. 'You know,—you, my brother.'

Louis XIV coloured again. That was the third time within an hour. 'Ask my lord cardinal,' replied he, in a tone which made Mazarin, Anne of Austria, and everybody else open their eyes.

'That means, my son,' said Anne of Austria, laughing, 'that the king does not like affairs of state to be talked of out of the council.'

Philip received the reprimand with good grace, and bowed, first smiling at his brother, and then at his mother. But Mazarin saw from the corner of his eye that a group was about to be formed in the corner of the room, and that the Duc d'Anjou, with the Comte de Guiche, and the Chevalier de Lorraine, prevented from talking aloud, might say, in a whisper, what it was not convenient should be said. He was beginning, then, to dart at them glances full of mistrust and uneasiness, inviting Anne of Austria to throw perturbation in the midst of the unlawful assembly; when, suddenly, Bernouin, entering from behind the tapestry of the bedroom, whispered in the ear of Mazarin, 'Monseigneur, an envoy from his majesty, the king of England.'

Mazarin could not help exhibiting a slight emotion, which was perceived by the king. To avoid being indiscreet, rather than to appear useless, Louis XIV rose immediately, and approaching his eminence, wished him good-night. All the assembly had risen with a great noise of rolling of chairs and tables being pushed away.

'Let everybody depart by degrees,' said Mazarin in a whisper to Louis XIV, 'and be so good as to excuse me a few minutes. I am going to dispatch an affair about which I wish to converse with your majesty this very evening.'

'And the queens?' asked Louis XIV

'And M. le Duc d'Anjou,' said his eminence.

Chapter XXXVIII

The French Grocer Had Already Been Established in the Seventeenth Century



It accounts once settled, and his recommendations made, D'Arragnan thought of nothing but returning to Paris as soon as possible. Athos, on his part, was anxious to reach home and to rest a little. However whole the character and the man may remain after the fatigues of a voyage, the traveller perceives with pleasure, at the close of the day—even though the day has been a fine one—that night is approaching, and will bring a little sleep with it. So, from Boulogne to Paris, jogging on, side by side, the two friends, in some degree absorbed each in his individual thoughts, conversed of nothing sufficiently interesting for us to repeat to our readers. Each of them given up to his personal reflections, and constructing his future after his own fashion, was, above all, anxious to abridge the distance by speed. Athos and D'Arragnan arrived at the gates of Paris on the evening of the fourth day after leaving Boulogne.

'Where are you going, my friend?' asked Athos. 'I shall direct my course straight to my hotel.'

'And I straight to my partner's.'

'To Planchet's?'

'Yes; at the Pilon d'Or.'

'Well, but shall we not meet again?'

'If you remain in Paris, yes; for I shall stay here.'

Chapter 39: Mazarin's Gaming Party

At the same time he turned round in his ruelle, the curtains of which, in falling, concealed the bed. The cardinal, nevertheless, did not lose sight of the conspirators.

'M. le Comte de Guiche,' said he, in a fretful voice, whilst putting on, behind the curtain, his dressing-gown, with the assistance of Bernouin.

'I am here, my lord,' said the young man, as he approached.

'Take my cards, you are lucky. Win a little money for me of these gentlemen.'

'Yes, my lord.'

The young man sat down at the table from which the king withdrew to talk with the two queens. A serious game was commenced between the comte and several rich courtiers. In the meantime Philip was discussing the questions of dress with the Chevalier de Lorraine, and they had ceased to hear the rustling of the cardinal's silk robe from behind the curtain. His eminence had followed Bernouin into the closet adjoining the bedroom.

LXI	The Cabaret of the Image-de-Notre-Dame	171
LXII	Vive Colbert!	179
LXIII	How M. d'Eymeris's Diamond Passed into the Hands of M. d'Artagnan	187
LXIV	Difference D'Artagnan Finds Between the Intendant and the Superintendent	195
LXV	Philosophy of the Heart and Mind	203
LXVI	The Journey	207
LXVII	How D'Artagnan Became Acquainted with a Poet . .	213
LXVIII	D'Artagnan Continues his Investigations	223
LXIX	D'Artagnan Was To Meet an Old Acquaintance . . .	231
LXX	Wherein the Ideas of D'Artagnan Begin To Clear Up a Little	239
LXXI	A Procession at Vannes	249
LXXII	The Grandeur of the Bishop of Vannes	257
LXXIII	In Which Porthos Begins To Be Sorry For Having Come With D'Artagnan	267
LXXIV	D'Artagnan Makes All Speed, Porthos Snores, and Ara- mis Counsels	279
LXXV	In Which Monsieur Fouquet Acts	287

Contents

XXXVIII	The French Grocer Had Already Been Established in the Seventeenth Century	1
XXXIX	Mazarin's Gaming Party	9
XL	An Affair of State	15
XLI	The Recital	21
XLII	In Which Mazarin Becomes Prodigal	27
XLIII	Guenaud	33
XLIV	Colbert	37
XLV	Confession of a Man of Wealth	43
XLVI	The Donation	49
XLVII	How Anne of Austria Gave One Piece of Advice to Louis XIV	55
XLVIII	Agony	65
XLIX	The First Appearance of Colbert	75
L	The First Day of the Royalty of Louis XIV	83
LI	A Passion	89
LII	D'Arragnan's Lesson	97
LIII	The King	105
LIV	The Houses of M. Fouquet	123
LV	The Abbé Fouquet	135
LVI	M. de la Fontaine's Wine	143
LVII	The Gallery of Saint-Mande	147
LVIII	Epicureans	153
LIX	A Quarter of an Hour's Delay	159
LX	Plan of Battle	165

Chapter XL

An Affair of State



HE cardinal, on passing into his cabinet, found the Comte de la Fère, who was waiting for him, engaged in admiring a very fine Raphael placed over a sideboard covered with a plate. His eminence came in softly, lightly, and as silently as a shadow, and surprised the countenance of the comte, as he was accustomed to do, pretending to divine by the simple expression of the face of his interlocutor what would be the result of the conversation.

But this time Mazarin was foiled in his expectation: he read nothing upon the face of Athos, not even the respect he was accustomed to see on all faces. Athos was dressed in black, with a simple lacing of silver. He wore the Holy Ghost, the Garter, and the Golden Fleece, three orders of such importance, that a king alone, or else a player, could wear them at once.

Mazarin rummaged a long time in his somewhat troubled memory to recall the name he ought to give to this icy figure, but he did not succeed. 'I am told,' said he, at length, 'you have a message from England for me.'

And he sat down, dismissing Bernouin, who, in his quality of secretary, was getting his pen ready.

'On the part of his majesty, the king of England, yes, your eminence.'

'You speak very good French for an Englishman, monsieur,' said Mazarin, graciously, looking through his fingers at the Holy Ghost, Garter, and Golden Fleece, but more particularly at the face of the messenger.

'I am not an Englishman, but a Frenchman, monsieur le cardinal,' replied Athos.

'It is remarkable that the king of England should choose a Frenchman for his ambassador; it is an excellent augury. Your name, monsieur, if you please.'

'Comte de la Fère,' replied Athos, bowing more slightly than the ceremonial and pride of the all-powerful minister required.

Mazarin bent his shoulders, as if to say:—

'I do not know that name.'

Athos did not alter his carriage.

'And you come, monsieur,' continued Mazarin, 'to tell me—'

'I come on the part of his majesty the king of Great Britain to announce to the king of France'—Mazarin frowned—'to announce to the king of France,' continued Athos, imperturbably, 'the happy restoration of his majesty Charles II to the throne of his ancestors.'

This shade did not escape his cunning eminence. Mazarin was too much accustomed to mankind, not to see in the cold and almost haughty politeness of Athos, an index of hostility, which was not of the temperate of that hot-house called a court.

'You have powers, I suppose?' asked Mazarin, in a short, querulous tone.

'Yes, monseigneur.' And the word 'monseigneur' came so painfully from the lips of Athos that it might be said it skinned them.

Athos took from an embroidered velvet bag which he carried under his doublet a dispatch. The cardinal held out his hand for it. 'Your pardon, monseigneur,' said Athos. 'My dispatch is for the king.'

'Since you are a Frenchman, monsieur, you ought to know the position of a prime minister at the court of France.'

'There was a time,' replied Athos, 'when I occupied myself with the importance of prime ministers; but I have formed, long ago, a resolution to treat no longer with any but the king.'

'Then, monsieur,' said Mazarin, who began to be irritated, 'you will neither see the minister nor the king.'

Mazarin rose. Athos replaced his dispatch in its bag, bowed gravely, and made several steps towards the door. This coolness exasperated Mazarin. 'What strange diplomatic proceedings are these!' cried he. 'Have we returned to the times when Cromwell sent us bulles in the guise of charges

THE VICOMTE DE BRAGELONNE VOL. II ALEXANDRE DUMAS



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MALCOLM PATTERSON